

The Framework on a Page

Warfighting imperative, enabling capability, organising system, developmental architecture, delivery and governance.

1 WARFIGHTING IMPERATIVE

COMBAT MINDSET

Remain effective. Act decisively. Harder to kill.

2 ENABLING CAPABILITY

PERFORMANCE UNDER PRESSURE

Prepare · Perform · Recover

3 ORGANISING SYSTEM

COMBAT MINDSET FRAMEWORK

Governs, develops, delivers and assures Performance Under Pressure and Combat Mindset.

4 DEVELOPMENTAL ARCHITECTURE

1

UNDERSTAND SELF

Recognise physiological and cognitive responses to pressure.

2

REGULATE SELF

Control the response so capability stays available.

3

PERFORM UNDER PRESSURE

Apply those capabilities while fatigued, overloaded and stressed.

4

LEAD UNDER PRESSURE

Maintain command presence, judgement, communication and influence.

5

PERFORM IN COMBAT CONDITIONS

Apply the capability under threat, uncertainty, consequence and ethical load.

Steps 1 to 4 build the enabling capability. Step 5 is its combat-specific expression: threat, consequence and ethical load.

5 DELIVERY PATHWAYS · EMBEDDED, NOT STANDALONE

PHYSICAL TRAINING

Daily and weekly practice of self-regulation under genuine physical interference

Steps 1 to 2

LEADERSHIP TRAINING

Perform and lead under interpersonal and decision pressure through LDS and ELDA

Steps 3 to 4

FIELD AND TACTICAL TRAINING

Apply the capability under combat-representative demands

Step 5

6 GOVERNANCE · PROPOSED

G7

doctrine and policy

ATG

training governance

ACS

learning provider

NZALC

development and delivery

TECHNICAL ADVISERS

APS · HPC · ILD · SMEs
advise and enable; do not own

Definitions and Principles

The drafting baseline endorsed on 10 September, and the principles that now shape the design.

COMBAT MINDSET

The individual and collective readiness and disposition to remain effective and act decisively and ethically under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat in order to achieve the mission. It is the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure.

PERFORMANCE UNDER PRESSURE

The trainable individual and collective human-performance capability to prepare for, maintain effective performance through, adapt within and recover from conditions that create significant physiological, cognitive, emotional or social interference.

COMBAT MINDSET FRAMEWORK

The framework through which Army governs, develops, delivers and assures Performance Under Pressure and its combat-specific expression, Combat Mindset.

THE COMBAT-SPECIFICITY TEST

A product, method or activity is combat-specific where it develops or applies Performance Under Pressure in a context that represents or deliberately simulates the defining demands of combat. Products that do not represent these demands contribute to the enabling capability rather than its combat-specific expression.

OPPOSITION OR THREAT

An adversary, or a credible representation of one

MISSION OR HUMAN CONSEQUENCE

Significant consequence attached to the outcome

ETHICAL LOAD

Decisions that carry moral weight under pressure

DESIGN PRINCIPLES

- 1 Organise and integrate before creating.**
The framework organises, standardises and connects what already exists. It is not another course or another piece of intellectual property.
- 2 Capability and outcomes first; products and organisations mapped beneath.**
The framework defines what Army develops and to what standard. Products, methods and organisations are then mapped against it, rather than the framework being built around any one of them.
- 3 Embedded delivery through existing pathways.**
Outcomes are carried in physical training, leadership training and field training, and in the course data sheets that already govern them.
- 4 Combat specificity by the defining demands.**
Performance Under Pressure techniques become Combat Mindset only when developed or applied against threat, consequence and ethical load.
- 5 Evidence and assurance built in.**
Progression, transfer to performance, product quality and organisational adoption are assessed at individual, product and system level.

WHAT HAS CHANGED SINCE V1.0

- The construct is endorsed: Combat Mindset as the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure (Option 1).
- Direction not to create a standalone course: organise, standardise and connect what exists, then embed it through existing training pathways.
- A proposed governance chain, G7 to ATG to ACS to NZALC, with APS, HPC and ILD as technical advisers rather than owners.
- A five-step developmental architecture in place of a product-by-product organisation.
- Physical training identified as the routine environment for practising self-regulation.
- A nearer decision point: AITC on or about 14 October 2026.

Developmental Architecture

Five steps from understanding the pressure response to performing in combat conditions. The framework's backbone.

STEP	WHAT IT MEANS	INDICATIVE CONTENT	WHERE IT IS DEVELOPED	LDF
1 UNDERSTAND SELF	Recognise physiological and cognitive responses to pressure.	Stress response, arousal, attention narrowing, working-memory load; the Performance = Potential minus Interference model; Red Head and Blue Head.	Recruit and initial training; Lead Self	Lead Self
2 REGULATE SELF	Control the response so capability stays available.	Breathing, arousal control, attention, posture and presence, cognitive control; Prepare, Perform, Recover; practised routinely under genuine physical interference.	Physical training; Lead Self and Lead Teams; performance cognition (developmental)	Lead Self
3 PERFORM UNDER PRESSURE	Apply those capabilities while fatigued, overloaded and stressed.	Task performance and decision-making under load; peer performance and recovery cycles; experiential activity with structured reflection.	JNCO course and ELDA Lead Teams; NZCC; unit training	Lead Teams
4 LEAD UNDER PRESSURE	Maintain command presence, judgement, communication and influence.	Leading others while regulating self; interpersonal and decision pressure; setting tone and climate when interference is high.	SNCO and WO courses; ELDA Lead Leaders and Lead Systems; command training	Lead Leaders to Lead Systems
5 PERFORM IN COMBAT CONDITIONS	Apply the capability under threat, uncertainty, consequence and ethical load.	The combat-specific expression: opposition or threat, significant mission or human consequence, and ethical load, represented or deliberately simulated.	Field, tactical and collective training; mission-specific preparation	All levels

Steps 1 to 4 build Performance Under Pressure and apply wherever significant pressure exists, with or without an enemy. The red line marks the combat-specificity test: step 5 is where the capability is developed or applied against opposition or threat, significant consequence and ethical load, and becomes Combat Mindset. The developmental steps are cumulative; a soldier at step 5 keeps practising steps 1 to 4.

Content, pathways and LDF alignment are indicative and will be confirmed through the Phase 2 assessment and Phase 4 validation.

Training Integration Map

Where the existing pathways contribute to each step. Indicative; confirmed in the Phase 2 assessment.

PATHWAY	1 UNDERSTAND SELF	2 REGULATE SELF	3 PERFORM UNDER PRESSURE	4 LEAD UNDER PRESSURE	5 PERFORM IN COMBAT CONDITIONS
Physical training Routine practice of physiological regulation, composure, attention, communication and presence under genuine physical interference	●	○	○		
Recruit and initial training LDS Lead Self; first exposure to the model and the language	●	○			
JNCO, SNCO and WO promotion courses NZALC LDS and ELDA Lead Teams, Lead Leaders and Lead Systems	○	●	●	●	○
Officer commissioning and ELDA NZCC with ELDA and LDS Lead Teams; ELDA Lead Leaders and Lead Systems	○	●	●	●	○
Performance cognition (HPC) COGCON: developmental; role, evidence, ownership and scale assessed in Phase 2	○	●	○		
Army Psychology Services Mental skills, psychological support and professional advice	●	●	○	○	
Field, tactical and collective training Application against the defining demands of combat; unit-owned		○	●	●	●
ILD, Lead Systems and above Tri-Service leadership development at senior levels			○	●	○

● Primary contribution

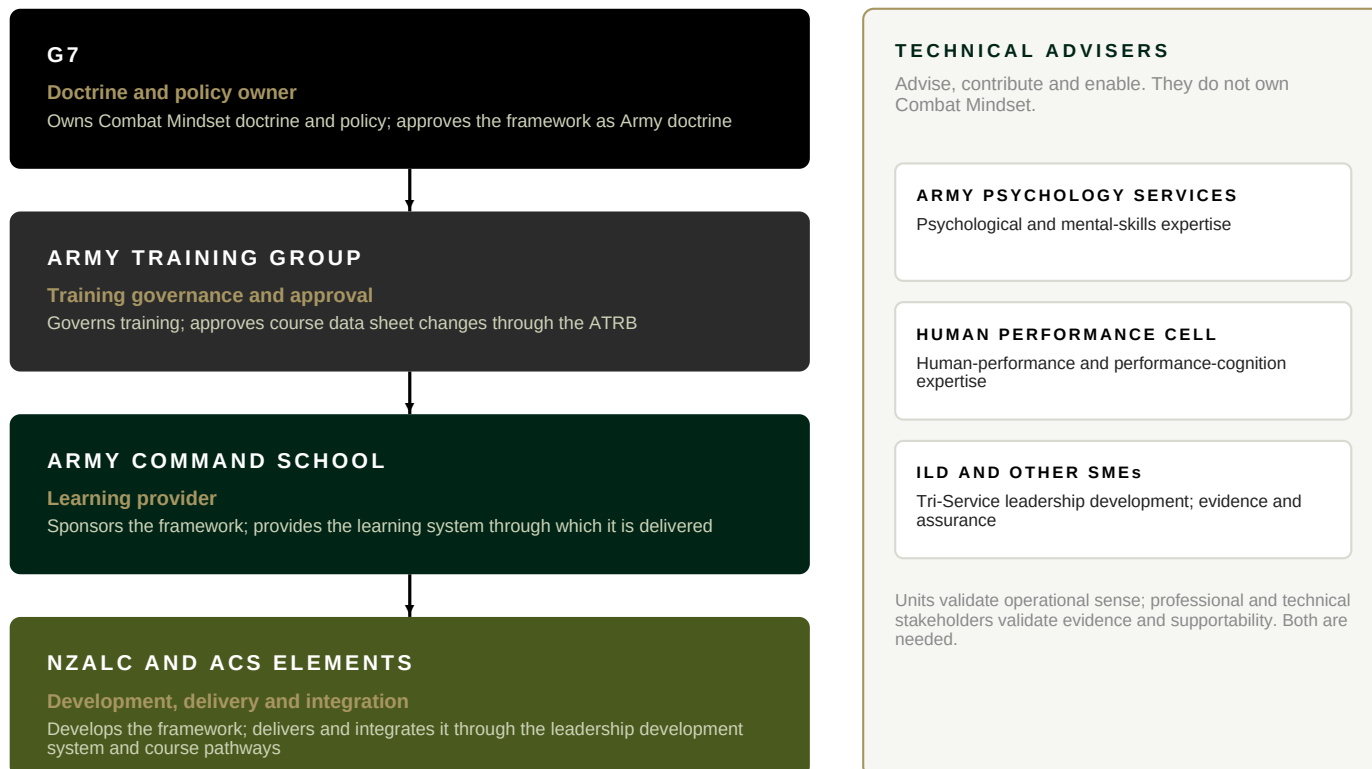
○ Contributes

HOW TO READ THE MAP

Read down a column to see which pathways develop a step; read across a row to see how far a pathway reaches. No single pathway carries the whole capability, and no pathway is the framework. Performance cognition and mental skills sit inside Performance Under Pressure as complementary components, psychological and cognitive skill alongside physiological self-regulation, trained progressively and then applied under increasingly representative pressure. The map is not an organisational turf chart.

Governance and Delivery Model

Proposed on the basis of COMDT ACS direction of 10 September. Enduring arrangements are confirmed through ATG.



DELIVERY MODEL

Embedded, not standalone

Combat Mindset outcomes are carried in the pathways soldiers and officers already pass through: physical training, recruit and promotion courses, ELDA, commissioning, and field training. No standalone Combat Mindset course is created.

One language across pathways

Common terminology, the developmental steps and the combat-specificity test are used by every pathway, whoever delivers it.

Owned through existing course governance

Outcomes enter course data sheets and are approved through the ATRB; PT and field application are directed through policy and guidance rather than new courses.

Assured at three levels

Individual and team: can people perform better under pressure? Product: does the intervention produce the outcome it claims? System: is Army consistently developing, delivering and assuring the capability?

Syllabus and CDS Architecture

What AITC would be approving: outcome statements carried into existing course data sheets, and where.

DRAFT DEVELOPMENTAL OUTCOMES

- 1 Recognises own physiological and cognitive responses to pressure and their effect on performance.
- 2 Regulates arousal, attention and cognitive load using trained techniques while under genuine interference.
- 3 Performs assigned tasks and makes sound decisions while fatigued, overloaded and stressed.
- 4 Leads others under pressure, maintaining command presence, judgement, communication and influence.
- 5 Applies the capability under threat, uncertainty, consequence and ethical load to achieve the mission.

WHERE THE OUTCOMES ARE CARRIED

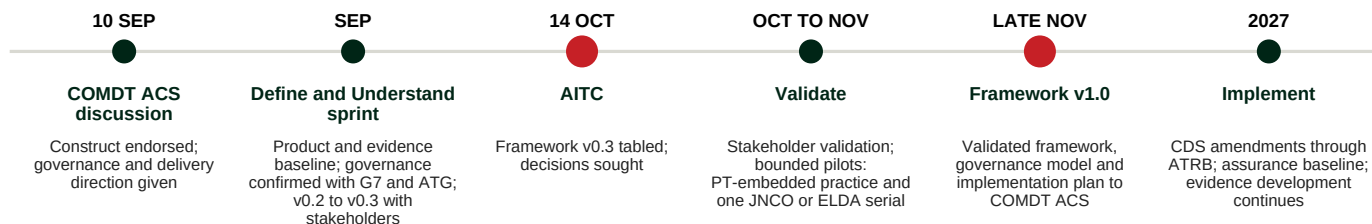
PATHWAY OR COURSE	LEVEL	OUTCOMES	CDS ACTION
Recruit training	Lead Self	1, 2	Amend: carry Understand Self and Regulate Self outcomes
Unit physical training programme	PT policy and unit programmes	2	Direct: embed regulation practice; no new course
A1530 JNCO Course with ELDA Lead Teams	Lead Teams	2, 3	Amend A1530 and A18011 to carry the outcomes
NZCC with ELDA and LDS Lead Teams	Lead Teams	2, 3	Amend NZCC CDS to carry the outcomes
A1531 SNCO Course with ELDA Lead Leaders	Lead Leaders	3, 4	Amend A1531 and A18008 to carry the outcomes
A1532 WO Course with ELDA Lead Systems	Lead Systems	4	Amend A1532 and A18010 to carry the outcomes
ELDA Command	Command teams	4, 5	Amend A18009; collective application under representative demands
COGCON	Developmental	2	Hold: Phase 2 assessment decides role, owner and scale
Field, tactical and collective training	Unit-owned	5	Guidance: combat-specific application standards; no new course

WHAT AITC IS ASKED TO APPROVE

The outcome statements and the principle that they are carried in existing course data sheets rather than in a new course. Individual CDS amendments follow through the ATRB once Framework v1.0 is approved. Course codes, levels and the outcome allocation are indicative and rest on the Phase 2 assessment; the COGCON row is held pending that assessment.

Implementation and Validation

A compressed Define, Understand and initial Design sprint to AITC, then validation to Framework v1.0.



DECISIONS SOUGHT FROM AITC, 14 OCTOBER 2026

1. Endorse the framework construct and the working definitions.
2. Endorse the five-step developmental architecture as the basis for outcomes.
3. Endorse the governance model in principle: G7, ATG, ACS, NZALC, with technical advisers.
4. Direct the embedded delivery approach: outcomes carried in existing pathways, no standalone course.
5. Note the validation plan and the intent to return Framework v1.0 in late November.

VALIDATION

INDIVIDUAL AND TEAM

Can people perform better under pressure?
Observed performance in bounded pilots against the outcome statements.

PRODUCT

Does each intervention produce the outcome it claims? Evidence maturity, transfer and scalability assessed in Phase 2 and tested in pilots.

SYSTEM

Is Army consistently developing, delivering and assuring the capability? Outcomes present in CDS, delivered as designed, and reported.

BOUNDED PILOTS, OCTOBER TO NOVEMBER

- PT-embedded self-regulation practice in one unit programme, with the PTI cadre.
- One JNCO Course or ELDA Lead Teams serial carrying outcomes 2 and 3 explicitly.
- Stakeholder validation of the map, governance and CDS architecture with ACS, NZALC, HPC, APS, ILD and selected units.

SEPARATE WORKSTREAM: LCFT CURRENCY

The 10 September discussion also produced a command decision on physical currency before promotion training: units certify LCFT currency, NCO School enforces it, and ELDA remains a developmental environment rather than an informal fitness assessment. That is progressed as its own workstream and is not part of the Combat Mindset Framework.